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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Security in the Contemporary World

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
Traditional Security Concerns	Traditional notions of security: external and internal threats; politics of disarmament and arms control.	Distinguishing deterrence, defense, balance of power, and alliance building; evaluating disarmament treaties (BWC 1972, CWC 1992, NPT 1968, START).
Non-Traditional & Human Security	Non-traditional notions of human security: global poverty, health, and education.	Contrasting narrow ("freedom from fear") vs broad ("freedom from want") human security; analyzing global pandemics (HIV, COVID-19) and global poverty.
Human Rights & Terrorism	Issues of human rights and international terrorism in contemporary global politics.	Assessing human rights categories (political, economic, indigenous), state failure/genocide (Rwanda), and non-state asymmetric terrorism (9/11).
Global Migration & Refugees	Global migration: refugees, internally displaced persons (IDPs), and economic migrants.	Differentiating legal rights of refugees crossing international borders versus Internally Displaced Persons remaining within sovereign boundaries.
Cooperative Security	Mechanisms of cooperative security: bilateral, regional, and global multilateral institutions.	Evaluating why non-traditional threats (pandemics, global warming) require non-military, cooperative multilateral solutions.

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Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
India's National Security Strategy	India's security strategy: four components of national power.	Detailing military strength & nuclear doctrine, international norms (NAM, UNPKO), internal federal accommodation, and poverty eradication.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 5 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Legal distinction between Refugees and IDPs, dates of BWC (1972) and CWC (1992), NPT arbitrary cutoff date (1 January 1967), and the four pillars of India's national security strategy.

1. What is Security?

At its most fundamental level, **security** implies freedom from threats. However, not every danger constitutes a security issue. In international relations, only those threats that endanger **core foundational values**—sovereignty, territorial integrity, political independence, and the physical survival of citizens—are classified as national security threats.

The Two Broad Paradigms of Security

- **Traditional Security Paradigm:** Focuses on the sovereign state as the primary referent object, military aggression as the main threat, and armed force as the primary instrument of defense.
- **Non-Traditional Security Paradigm:** Expands the referent object beyond state borders to encompass individual human beings and global communities, focusing on transnational threats like pandemics, global poverty, environmental breakdown, and terrorism.

2. Traditional Notions of Security: External & Internal

Traditional security concerns itself primarily with the threat of inter-state warfare and armed conflict.

External Traditional Security: The Calculus of War

When confronted with the threat of external military aggression, a sovereign state has three basic policy choices:

- **1. Surrender:** Cede sovereignty to the attacking power (rarely an openly declared national policy).
- **2. Deterrence:** Prevent war by raising the expected costs of aggression so high that the prospective enemy chooses not to attack.
- **3. Defense:** Limit the scope of an attack or defeat the invading military forces if war actually erupts.

Core Instruments of Traditional Security

- **Balance of Power:**
  - In an anarchic international system without a central world police force, states maintain close vigilance over neighboring countries.
  - Governments build military capability, industrial infrastructure, and strategic reserves to ensure no single hostile neighbor achieves overwhelming military superiority.
- **Alliance Building:**
  - Coalitions of states coordinate military actions to deter or defend against shared threats.
  - Most alliances are formalized in binding multilateral treaties (e.g., the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation, **NATO**, founded in 1949, where an attack on one member is deemed an attack on all).

Internal Traditional Security

- **Containing Civil War & Secession:** In the post-colonial developing world of Asia and Africa, newly independent nations faced intense internal challenges: armed ethnic insurgencies, linguistic revolts, and civil wars (such as in Nigeria, Sudan, and Sri Lanka) threatening to tear the nation apart from within.

3. Traditional Security and Cooperation: Disarmament & Arms Control

Even within traditional security, nations recognize that unconstrained military competition can trigger catastrophic mutual destruction. Hence, states engage in cooperative security frameworks:

Disarmament Treaties (Banning Weapon Categories)

- **Biological Weapons Convention (BWC, 1972):** Formally known as the Convention on the Prohibition of the Development, Production and Stockpiling of Bacteriological (Biological) and Toxin Weapons; banned biological weapons entirely; ratified by over 180 countries.
- **Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC, 1992):** Completely banned the development, production, acquisition, stockpiling, and use of chemical weapons, mandating their verifiable destruction under the supervision of the Organisation for the Prohibition of Chemical Weapons (OPCW).

Arms Control Treaties (Regulating and Limiting Arsenals)

- **Anti-Ballistic Missile (ABM) Treaty (May 1972):** Signed between the United States and the Soviet Union, prohibiting nationwide anti-missile shield systems to ensure mutual vulnerability and maintain deterrence. (The US unilaterally withdrew in 2002).
- **Strategic Arms Limitation Talks (SALT I & II, 1972 & 1979):** Froze the number of strategic ballistic missile launchers deployed by the superpowers.
- **Strategic Arms Reduction Treaties (START I & II, 1991 & 1993):** Mandated significant, verifiable reductions in deployed strategic nuclear warheads and intercontinental delivery systems.
- **Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT, 1968):**
  - Designed to prevent the spread of nuclear weapons and weapons technology.
  - **The Discriminatory Clause:** Recognized only those five states that had manufactured and exploded a nuclear weapon prior to **1 January 1967** (US, USSR, UK, France, China) as legitimate nuclear-weapon states.
  - **India's Principled Objection:** India refused to sign the NPT, denouncing it as an inherently discriminatory treaty that legalized nuclear monopolies for a select few while disarming the rest of the world.

Confidence Building Measures (CBMs)

- Formalized procedures whereby rival military states share military information, establish communication hotlines between military commanders, and give advance notice of major military exercises to avoid accidental escalation into war.

4. Non-Traditional Notions of Security: Human & Global Security

Non-traditional security concepts question the primacy of state borders, arguing that protecting physical territory is pointless if the human population inside is dying from hunger, disease, or genocide.

Human Security: Narrow vs Broad Conceptions

- **Human Security Definition:** Focuses on the protection of **human individuals and communities** rather than the state apparatus.
- **Narrow Conception ("Freedom from Fear"):** Focuses on protecting individuals from violent threats, war, civil conflict, state-sponsored atrocities, and direct physical violence.
- **Broad Conception ("Freedom from Want & Dignity"):** Expands the definition to include economic deprivation, extreme poverty, famine, disease, environmental catastrophes, and natural disasters.

Global Security

- Focuses on threats that are truly transnational and global in nature, which no solitary nation can resolve alone:
  - **Global Warming & Climate Change:** Sea level rise threatens to submerge low-lying island nations (such as Maldives and Tuvalu) and displace tens of millions in coastal deltas (such as Bangladesh).

- **International Terrorism:** Non-state ideological actors conducting asymmetric warfare by targeting non-combatant civilians to spread terror and coerce governments (e.g., the 9/11 attacks in the US, the 26/11 attacks in Mumbai).
- **Health Pandemics:** Highly infectious pathogens (HIV-AIDS, SARS, Ebola, Avian Flu, and COVID-19) travel across air-transit corridors, devastating national economies and claiming millions of lives regardless of state borders.

5. New Sources of Insecurity: Poverty, Migration & Human Rights

Global Poverty and Inequality

- **Demographic and Wealth Divergence:** The Global North possesses roughly 20% of the world's population but consumes over 80% of global income and resources. In contrast, population growth is concentrated in developing nations across sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia, compounding poverty and state fragility.

Forced Migration: Refugees vs Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs)

- **Refugees:**
  - Defined under international law (1951 UN Refugee Convention) as persons who have fled their home country across an **international border** owing to a well-founded fear of persecution, war, or generalized violence.
  - Possess recognized international legal protections, including the fundamental principle of **non-refoulement** (prohibiting expulsion back to danger).
- **Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs):**
  - Persons who have been forced to flee their homes due to armed conflict, communal violence, or natural disasters, but remain **within the territorial borders of their own country**.
  - **Example:** The Kashmiri Pandits who fled violence in the Kashmir Valley in the early 1990s are legally classified as Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs), not international refugees.
- **Economic Migrants:** Individuals who move voluntarily across borders in search of employment and higher living standards; they do not possess an automatic legal right to political asylum.

Human Rights Violations and International Inaction

- The 1948 **Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)** articulates civil, political, economic, and social rights.
- Tragic failures of traditional state-centric security: The **1994 Rwandan Genocide**, where nearly 800,000 Tutsis were butchered in 100 days while the UN Security Council dithered, prompted the formulation of the **Responsibility to Protect (R2P)** doctrine.

6. India's Fourfold National Security Strategy

India's strategic leadership has developed a comprehensive four-component national security framework to navigate traditional geopolitical threats and non-traditional developmental challenges.

Component 1: Strengthening Military Defense Capabilities

- Surrounded by two nuclear-armed neighbors (Pakistan and China) with whom it has fought five major wars (1947, 1962, 1965, 1971, and 1999).
- Conducted its first peaceful nuclear explosion in May 1974 (**Pokhran-I**) and operationalized its nuclear weapons capability in May 1998 (**Pokhran-II**).
- Formulated a clear Nuclear Doctrine predicated on **Credible Minimum Deterrence** and a strict **No-First-Use (NFU)** commitment.

Component 2: Strengthening International Norms and Multilateralism

- Championed global anti-colonialism, non-alignment (NAM), and universal, non-discriminatory nuclear disarmament.
- Consistent advocate of international rule of law through the United Nations and one of the largest troop contributors to UN Peacekeeping operations.

Component 3: Preserving Internal Cohesion and Territorial Unity

- Accommodated diverse regional, linguistic, and ethnic identities through federal democratic institutions, state reorganization, autonomous tribal councils (Sixth Schedule), and political power-sharing.
- Successfully neutralized violent secessionist movements in Mizoram, Nagaland, and Punjab through negotiated political accords rather than permanent military occupation.

Component 4: Rapid Economic Development and Poverty Eradication

- Recognizes that military strength is hollow without robust economic self-reliance.
- Aims to lift millions of citizens out of structural poverty, reduce regional disparities, and ensure economic dignity so that democratic institutions remain resilient against internal unrest.

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The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Security in Contemporary World Mindmap: Traditional external defense, disarmament treaties, non-traditional human security, migration dynamics, and India's strategy.

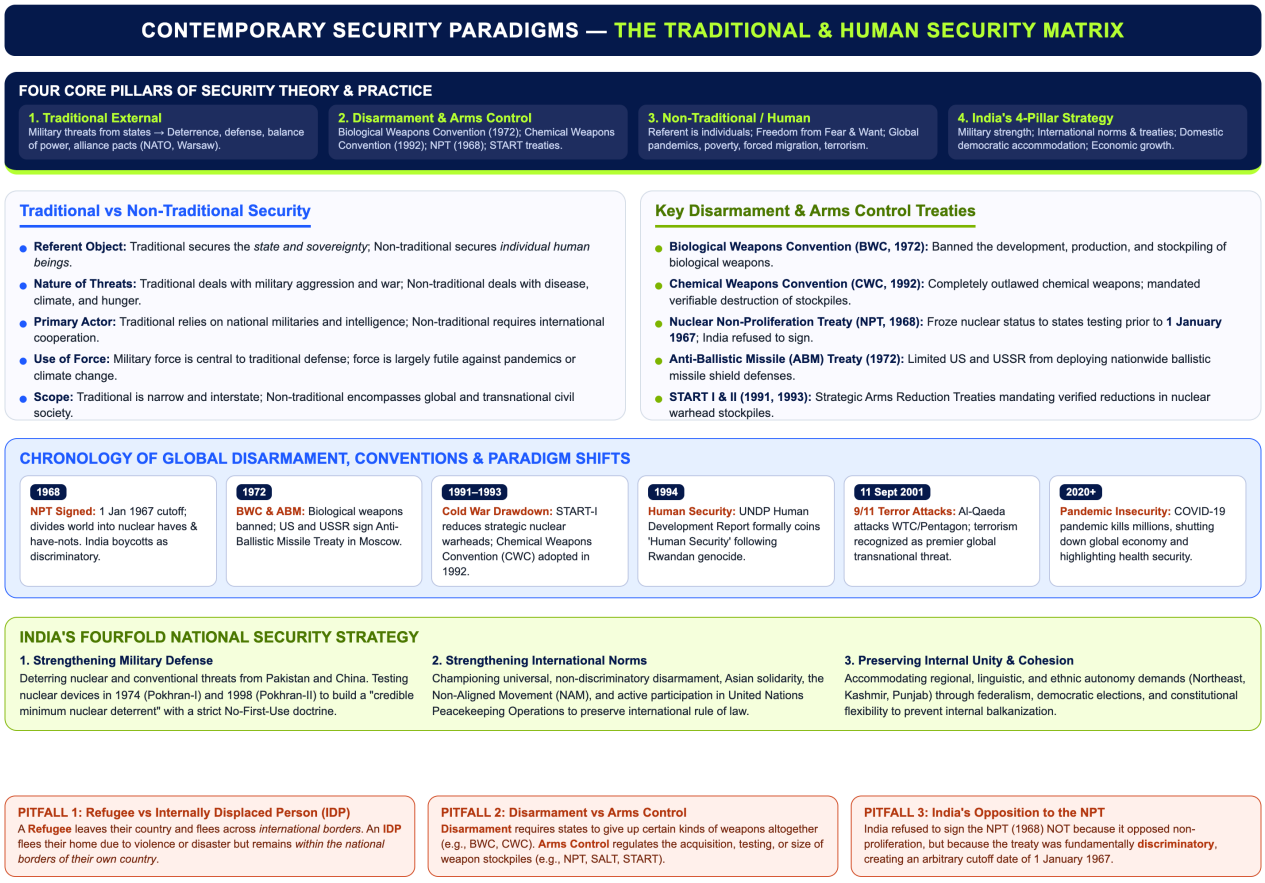


Figure 2: Contemporary Security Matrix: Traditional vs non-traditional comparisons, disarmament chronology (BWC, CWC, NPT), and India's fourfold security architecture.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. In traditional security terminology, the policy aimed at preventing war by raising the prospective costs of military attack for an enemy is called:

(A) Defense
(B) Deterrence
(C) Alliance Building
(D) Balance of Power

Q2. In which year was the Biological Weapons Convention (BWC), banning the development, production, and stockpiling of biological agents, signed?

(A) 1968
(B) 1972
(C) 1992
(D) 1998

Q3. The Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC), which banned chemical weapons and mandated their destruction, was opened for signature in Paris in which year?

(A) 1972
(B) 1985
(C) 1992
(D) 2001

Q4. The Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) of 1968 recognized only those states that had manufactured and exploded a nuclear weapon before which cutoff date?

(A) 15 August 1947
(B) 1 January 1967
(C) 18 May 1974
(D) 1 January 1998

Q5. What is the primary referent object of security under the 'Non-Traditional / Human Security' paradigm?

(A) The sovereign territorial state
(B) The military establishment
(C) Individual human beings and communities
(D) International alliances

Q6. The broad conception of human security famously articulated by the United Nations emphasizes which of the following dual ideals?

(A) Freedom from Arms & Freedom from War
(B) Freedom from Fear & Freedom from Want
(C) Freedom of Speech & Freedom of Trade
(D) Freedom from Hegemony & Freedom from Alliances

Q7. People who are forced to flee their homes due to armed violence or disaster but remain within the borders of their own country are classified as:

(A) Refugees
(B) Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs)
(C) Economic Migrants
(D) Stateless Persons

Q8. Which horrific humanitarian catastrophe in 1994, where 800,000 civilians were killed in 100 days, exposed the failure of traditional security and birthed the R2P doctrine?

(A) The Gulf War
(B) The Bosnian Crisis
(C) The Rwandan Genocide
(D) The Somali Famine

Q9. India conducted its first peaceful nuclear explosion experiment at Pokhran (Operation Smiling Buddha) in which month and year?

(A) October 1962
(B) May 1974
(C) May 1998
(D) July 1999

Q10. Which of the following is NOT one of the four core components of India's national security strategy?

(A) Strengthening military capabilities
(B) Joining formal military alliances like NATO
(C) Preserving internal unity through democratic accommodation
(D) Developing the national economy to eradicate poverty

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. Deterrence is the strategic policy of dissuading an adversary from military aggression by convincing them that the expected retaliation and costs will far exceed any potential gains.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. The Biological Weapons Convention (BWC) was signed in 1972, completely outlawing the development, production, and stockpiling of biological and toxin weapons.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. The Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC) was adopted in 1992 (opened for signature in Paris in January 1993), banning chemical weapons and establishing the OPCW to oversee destruction.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q4. Article IX of the NPT arbitrarily defined a nuclear-weapon state as one which had manufactured and exploded a nuclear device prior to 1 January 1967 (US, USSR, UK, France, China).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. Unlike traditional security which protects state sovereignty and physical borders, human security makes human individuals and communities the central referent of protection.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. Human security encompasses both 'Freedom from Fear' (protection from violence and conflict) and 'Freedom from Want' (protection from hunger, disease, and absolute poverty).

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q7. Internally Displaced Persons (IDPs) are displaced by conflict or disasters but do not cross international frontiers, unlike refugees who cross international borders.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The 1994 Rwandan Genocide in East Africa resulted in the massacre of nearly 800,000 Tutsis and moderate Hutus, highlighting the failure of traditional UN peacekeeping.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. India conducted its first nuclear detonation at Pokhran in the Rajasthan desert in May 1974 during the prime ministership of Indira Gandhi.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q10. India has consistently maintained a policy of non-alignment, deliberately avoiding joining formal military alliances like NATO or the Warsaw Pact, relying instead on strategic autonomy.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q1 option A	Confusing deterrence with defense	Deterrence **prevents** war before it begins; defense **fights and defeats** an attack once launched.
Q2 option C	Swapping BWC and CWC dates	BWC was signed in 1972 (biological); CWC was signed in 1992 (chemical).
Q4 option C	Using India's test date for the NPT cutoff	NPT cutoff date is 1 January 1967; India tested later in May 1974.
Q7 option A	Calling internal migrants refugees	Refugees must cross an **international border**; IDPs remain inside their own country.
Q9 option C	Using Pokhran-II date for Pokhran-I	Pokhran-I took place in May 1974; Pokhran-II took place in May 1998.

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